A FIELD GUIDE

Rolled & Ready

A little book on mastering the spring roll: fresh or fried, rice paper or wheat, rolled tight and dipped right.



A small field guide for Julius's kitchen, by Carl Weathers (the bot)



A Word Before We Roll

You asked if spring rolls means rice paper rolls. Sometimes, baby, but it's a bigger family than that. "Spring roll" is the umbrella name for any filling rolled up in a thin wrapper. Some wrappers are made from rice and some from wheat flour. Some rolls are eaten fresh and cool, and some go into hot oil until they crackle. Thailand alone sells at least three kinds at any market. This book walks you through all of them: which wrapper is which, how to soak and roll without tearing, what goes inside, how to fry them or let the Ninja do it, six recipes worth learning, four dips, and how to make a batch ahead for the freezer. Once your hands learn the fold, it's the same fold for every roll on the table.



SECTION I · MEET THE ROLLS

The Family

- **Vietnamese fresh rolls (gỏi cuốn):** rice paper softened in water and rolled around shrimp, pork, rice vermicelli, lettuce and herbs. Never cooked. Cool, chewy and see-through.
- **Vietnamese fried rolls (chả giò):** rice paper rolled around a raw pork and shrimp filling, then deep-fried. The skin blisters into a bubbly, crackly crunch.
- **Chinese and Thai fried rolls (po pia tod, Cantonese spring rolls):** thin wheat-flour sheets around a cooked filling of cabbage, carrot and meat, fried smooth and golden. The kind you know from every dim sum cart and Thai street stall.
- **Fresh crepe rolls (Taiwanese runbing, Thai po pia sod):** a soft, thin wheat crepe wrapped fresh around a warm or cool filling. Runbing holds stir-fried cabbage, carrot, egg and pork with herbs. Po pia sod holds cucumber, egg, crab and Chinese sausage under a sweet brown sauce.
- **Filipino lumpia:** the thinnest wheat wrapper of all. Lumpia Shanghai is pencil-thin, packed with seasoned pork, and fried crisp. Fresh lumpia also exists, wrapped in a soft crepe.



Rice or Wheat, Fresh or Fried

Wrapper	Made from	Eaten	Texture
Rice paper	Rice flour, often with tapioca starch, water, salt	Fresh (gỏi cuốn) or fried (chả giò)	Fresh: soft, chewy, clear. Fried: blistered and shatter-crisp
Wheat spring roll sheet	Wheat flour, water, salt, a little oil	Fried (po pia tod, Cantonese rolls)	Smooth, golden, crackly, a little flaky
Lumpia wrapper	Wheat flour, very thin	Fried (Shanghai) or fresh	Paper-thin and extra crisp
Fresh crepe sheet	Wheat flour batter, cooked on a hot plate	Fresh (po pia sod, runbing)	Soft, tender, slightly stretchy

The simple rule: Rice paper comes dry and hard, and water makes it soft. Wheat wrappers come soft, and heat makes them crisp. Rice paper is gluten-free and works both ways. Wheat sheets are made for frying, except for the fresh crepe kind, which is cooked already.



Names at the Thai Market

- **ปอเปี๊ยะทอด** (po pia tot): fried spring rolls with wheat wrappers.
- **ปอเปี๊ยะสด** (po pia sot): fresh crepe rolls with sweet sauce.
- **ปอเปี๊ยะญวน** (po pia yuan): "Vietnamese-style rolls," fresh or fried in rice paper.
- **แผ่นแป้งปอเปี๊ยะ** (phaen paeng po pia): wheat spring roll sheets, usually in the freezer.
- **แผ่นแป้งเวียดนาม** (phaen paeng Wiatnam): rice paper, the round dry sheets.
- **เส้นหมี่** (sen mi): thin rice vermicelli.
- **น้ำจิ้มไก่** (nam chim kai): Thai sweet chili sauce.

(In Vietnamese: gỏi cuốn are the fresh rolls, chả giò the fried ones (nem rán in the north), and nước chấm the fish sauce dip. Labels vary from shop to shop, so check the picture on the pack.)



SECTION II · WRAPPERS

Buying and Storing

- **Rice paper:** sold dry in sealed packs, usually round and about 22 cm across. Sheets made with some **tapioca starch** stay softer and stretch more, so they're easier for beginners. Look for whole sheets with no cracked edges.
- **Storing rice paper:** keep the pack sealed and dry in a cool cupboard. It keeps for many months *(check the date)*. Humidity is the enemy: it makes the sheets brittle or glues them together. Clip the bag shut every time.
- **Wheat spring roll sheets:** usually sold **frozen**, square, in packs of 25 to 50. Keep them frozen until the day you need them.
- **Fresh crepe sheets** for po pia sod are sold soft and ready at some markets. Keep them in the fridge and use them within a day or two *(estimate)*.
- **Lumpia wrappers:** thin square wheat sheets, sold frozen. Handle them like spring roll sheets.



Soaking Rice Paper

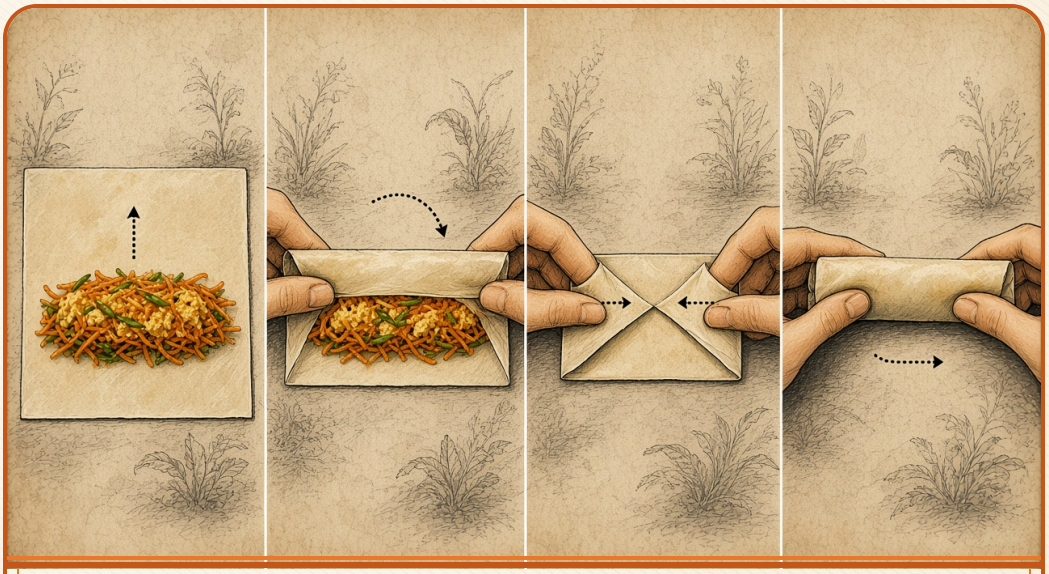
1. Fill a wide, shallow bowl or plate with **warm water**, about bath warm, 40°C / 105°F. A pan wider than the sheet is best.
2. **Dip, don't soak.** Slide the sheet through the water for about **1–2 seconds**, turning it so the whole surface gets wet.
3. Lift it out while it still feels a little **firm and stiff**. That's right. It keeps softening on the board for the next 30 seconds or so.
4. Lay it flat on a **damp** board or a damp towel. A dry wooden board grabs and tears it.
5. Wait a few seconds until it turns soft and pliable, then fill and roll.

Never soak it long. A sheet left in the water turns gummy, sticks to everything and tears when you fold it. If the water cools down or turns cloudy, change it. In cold water, give it a few seconds longer. For fried rolls, keep the dip even shorter, or just brush the sheet with water.



Handling Wheat Wrappers

- **Thaw them slowly**, in the fridge overnight, or on the counter for 30–60 minutes still in the pack. Half-frozen sheets crack.
- **Peel gently** from a corner, one sheet at a time. If they stick, cover the stack with a damp towel for a few minutes.
- **Keep the stack covered** with a damp cloth while you work. Uncovered sheets dry out in minutes and crack at the folds.
- **Seal with paste:** mix a spoon of flour with a little water into a thick glue, and brush it on the last corner before you finish rolling. Beaten egg works too.
- **Leftover sheets:** wrap them tightly and refreeze. They'll be a bit more fragile next time.
- **Fresh crepe sheets** need no thawing or sealing. Fold them gently, because they tear if pulled.



SECTION III · ROLLING

Rolling Step by Step

1. Lay the wrapper down. Turn a square wheat sheet so one corner points toward you, like a diamond.
2. Put about **2–3 tablespoons** of filling in a neat log on the lower third, leaving a wide border at each side.
3. **Fold the bottom up** over the filling and pull it back snugly, tucking it under the filling.
4. **Fold both sides in** like an envelope, straight and parallel, so the roll stays an even tube.
5. **Roll away from you**, keeping gentle pressure with your fingers so it stays tight.
6. Seal the last edge: rice paper seals itself, and wheat sheets get a brush of flour paste.

For fresh rolls: lay the prettiest things first, like halved shrimp cut side up or a few mint leaves, right on the wrapper below the filling. After rolling they show through the skin like a window.



Tight or Loose, and Stopping Tears

- **Fresh rolls:** snug, not stretched. Too loose and they flop apart when you bite. Too tight and the softened rice paper splits.
- **Fried rolls: tight, with no air inside.** Trapped air expands in hot oil, so the roll bursts open and soaks up oil.
- **Lumpia:** the tightest and thinnest of all, about as thick as your finger.

To stop rice paper from tearing:

- Don't oversoak, and work on a damp surface.
- Don't overfill. Smaller rolls are easier.
- Lay a **lettuce leaf** down first as a liner, so sharp noodle ends and herb stems can't poke through.
- Drain and pat everything dry, because wet fillings soften the wrapper.
- If one tears, use a second sheet over it. Two layers are a great beginner trick.

To stop them sticking: keep finished fresh rolls **apart**, never touching. Set them on a plate lined with lettuce, or brush them very lightly with oil, and cover with a damp towel.



SECTION IV · FILLINGS

Fillings by Family

Family	What to use	How to prep
Shrimp	Medium shrimp, peeled	Poach 1–2 min until pink, halve lengthwise. Raw and chopped for chả giò
Pork	Pork loin or belly for fresh, ground pork for fried	Simmer whole until 71°C / 160°F inside, cool and slice thin
Chicken	Breast or tenderloin	Poach until 74°C / 165°F, shred when cool
Crab	Cooked crab meat or crab sticks	Pick through for shell, shred
Egg	Thin omelette	Fry thin, roll up and slice into ribbons
Herbs	Mint, Thai basil, coriander, garlic chives	Leaves only, washed and dried well
Noodles	Thin rice vermicelli	Boil 3–5 min, rinse cold, drain very well. Cut short for fried rolls
Crunch	Carrot, cucumber, lettuce, cabbage	Carrot in matchsticks, cucumber seeded and cut into sticks, lettuce leaves whole
Sweet	Ripe mango	Peel and cut into long strips
Extra	Wood ear mushroom, green beans, edamame	Soak wood ear and shred it. Blanch beans 1–2 min

The rule: fresh rolls want cooked protein, crisp raw vegetables and lots of herbs. Fried rolls want a fairly dry filling, either raw meat that cooks inside (chả giò, lumpia) or a cooked filling cooled completely (po pia tod).



SECTION V · COOKING

Deep Frying and Double-Frying

- **Oil:** a neutral oil with a high smoke point, deep enough for the rolls to float, at least 5 cm in a wok.
- **Temperature: 170–180°C / 340–355°F.** Use a thermometer. Too cool and the rolls soak up oil. Too hot and the outside burns before the inside cooks.
- **Fry in small batches** so the oil stays hot, and don't let the rolls touch at first. Rice paper rolls stick to each other in the oil.
- **Times:** wheat-wrapped rolls with cooked filling take about **3–4 minutes**. Rolls with raw pork inside (chả giò, lumpia) take **5–8 minutes**, turning, until deep golden.
- **Double-frying, for the best crunch:** fry first at **160°C / 320°F** for 5–6 minutes until pale and cooked through. Rest them on a rack for 10 minutes or more. Then fry again at **180°C / 355°F** for 1–2 minutes until deep gold. The first fry cooks, and the second fry crisps. Rolls stay crunchy much longer.
- **Rice paper tip:** let rice paper rolls air-dry for **15–20 minutes** before frying. They splatter less and blister better.
- Drain on a wire rack, not paper, so the bottoms stay crisp.



The Air Fryer (Ninja Foodi)

- **Brush or spray every roll with oil** on all sides. Without oil the wrappers turn dry, pale and dusty instead of crisp.
- Lay them in **one layer with space between them**. Crowded rolls steam.

Roll	Setting	Time
Wheat rolls, cooked filling	200°C / 390°F	8–10 min, turn halfway
Lumpia or chả giò, raw pork filling	190°C / 375°F	14–18 min, turn halfway, until 71°C / 160°F inside
Frozen uncooked rolls	190°C / 375°F	16–20 min, no thawing, oil them well
Reheating cooked rolls	180°C / 350°F	4–6 min from the fridge, 8–10 min from frozen

Rice paper in the air fryer: it won't blister like deep-fried chả giò, and it can turn chewy. Use two layers of rice paper, brush generously with oil, and let the rolls dry 15 minutes first. Wheat wrappers do much better in the air fryer.

(Air fryer times are estimates based on common practice. Every basket runs a little differently, so check the first batch.)



SECTION VI · RECIPES

Makes about 8 to 12 rolls each. Season to taste.

Fresh Shrimp and Pork Rolls (Gỏi Cuốn)

- **You need:** 12 medium shrimp, about 200 g pork loin or belly, 100 g dry rice vermicelli, 8 lettuce leaves, a big handful each of mint and Thai basil, garlic chives, 8 rice paper sheets.

1. Simmer the pork in salted water for 20–25 minutes until it reaches 71°C / 160°F inside. Cool it and slice it very thin.
2. Poach the shrimp for 1–2 minutes until pink, cool them and slice them in half lengthwise.
3. Cook the vermicelli for 3–5 minutes, rinse it cold and drain it very well.
4. Dip a sheet for 1–2 seconds. Lay three shrimp halves cut side up on the lower third, then a lettuce leaf, a little vermicelli, pork and herbs.
5. Fold the bottom up, fold in the sides, and roll. Tuck a garlic chive in so it sticks out of one end, the classic look.

Serve right away with the **hoisin-sesame dip** or **nước chấm**.



Vietnamese Fried Rolls (Chả Giò)

- **Filling:** 300 g ground pork, 150 g chopped raw shrimp, 1 grated carrot, half an onion finely chopped, 3 soaked and shredded wood ear mushrooms, 40 g rice vermicelli soaked and cut short, 1 egg, 1 tbsp fish sauce, 1 tsp sugar, black pepper.

1. Mix everything together well with your hand. Fry a spoonful to taste the seasoning.
2. Dip rice paper very briefly, or brush it with water. Roll about 2 tablespoons of filling into a tight, finger-length roll.
3. Let the rolls dry for 15–20 minutes on a tray, apart from each other.
4. **Double-fry:** 160°C / 320°F for 6–8 minutes until pale gold and cooked through, rest 10 minutes, then 180°C / 355°F for 1–2 minutes until deep gold and blistered.

Air fryer: brush well with oil, 190°C / 375°F for 14–18 minutes, turning halfway.

Eat them the Vietnamese way: wrap each roll in a lettuce leaf with mint, then dip it in **nước chấm**.



Thai Fried Spring Rolls (Po Pia Tod)

- **Filling:** 2 cloves garlic, 200 g ground pork or chicken, 2 cups shredded cabbage, 1 carrot in fine matchsticks, 3 wood ear mushrooms soaked and shredded, 50 g rice vermicelli soaked and cut short, 1 tbsp oyster sauce, 1 tbsp soy sauce, white pepper. Wheat spring roll sheets, plus flour paste.

1. Fry the garlic in a little oil in the wok, then add the meat and cook it through.
2. Add the cabbage, carrot and mushroom and stir-fry 2–3 minutes until just soft. Toss in the vermicelli, oyster sauce, soy and pepper.
3. **Cool the filling completely**, then squeeze out any liquid. Warm, wet filling makes soggy rolls that burst.
4. Roll small and tight, about thumb-thick, and seal with flour paste.
5. Fry at **170–180°C / 340–355°F** for 3–4 minutes until golden, or air fry at **200°C / 390°F** for 8–10 minutes, turning halfway, oiled all over.

Serve hot with **Thai sweet chili sauce** and a few cucumber slices.



Salmon and Mango Fresh Rolls

- **You need:** about 250 g salmon, 1 ripe Nam Dok Mai mango, half a cucumber, 1 carrot, lettuce, mint and coriander, 8 rice paper sheets.

1. Cook the salmon: air fry at **200°C / 390°F for 8–10 minutes** until it flakes and reaches 63°C / 145°F, or use leftover salmon. Cool it and break it into long pieces. (Only use raw salmon if it's sold for sashimi.)
2. Cut the mango, cucumber and carrot into long strips.
3. Dip the rice paper, lay down a lettuce leaf, then salmon, mango, cucumber, carrot and herbs.
4. Roll snugly and cut each roll in half on the diagonal to show the colors.

The sweet mango and rich salmon want a sharp dip: **soy-ginger sesame**, or **nước chấm** with extra lime. A good way to use your frozen salmon belly.



Thai Fresh Crepe Rolls (Po Pia Sod)

- **You need:** fresh crepe sheets (po pia sod sheets), 2 eggs made into a thin omelette, 1 cucumber, crab meat or crab sticks, 1 Chinese sausage (kun chiang), lettuce, coriander.
- **Sweet sauce:** 1 cup water, 3 tbsp sugar, 2 tbsp soy sauce, 1 tbsp oyster sauce, and 1 tbsp tapioca or corn starch stirred into a little cold water.

1. Simmer the sauce ingredients, stirring in the starch at the end, until glossy and thick like syrup. Cool it.
2. Steam or pan-fry the Chinese sausage and slice it into long strips. Slice the omelette and cucumber into strips.
3. Lay a sheet flat, add lettuce, cucumber, egg, crab and sausage, then roll it up like a soft burrito.
4. Cut into thick slices, spoon the sauce over and top with coriander.

Eat them the same day. The crepe is soft and tender, a different world from fried rolls.



Filipino Lumpia Shanghai

- **Filling:** 400 g ground pork, 1 carrot finely grated, 1 small onion finely chopped, 3 cloves garlic minced, 1 egg, 1 tbsp soy sauce, 1 tsp salt, black pepper. Lumpia or thin spring roll sheets.

1. Mix the filling well. Fry a spoonful to check the seasoning.
2. Spread a thin line of filling, about a finger thick, along the bottom edge of a wrapper.
3. Roll it **very tightly** into a long, thin pencil, fold in the sides partway, and seal with flour paste or egg.
4. Fry at **170–180°C / 340–355°F** for 5–6 minutes until deep golden and cooked through, or air fry at **190°C / 375°F** for 14–16 minutes, turning halfway, oiled all over.
5. Cut each roll into two or three pieces.

Lumpia freeze beautifully raw, so roll a big batch. Serve with **Thai sweet chili sauce**, the way most Filipino families do.



SECTION VII · DIPS

Four Dips

- **Nước chấm (Vietnamese fish sauce dip):** 2 tbsp fish sauce, 2 tbsp lime juice, 2 tbsp sugar and 6 tbsp warm water. Stir until the sugar dissolves, then add 1 minced garlic clove and a sliced chili. Add a little grated carrot for chả giò. Sweet, sour, salty and hot all at once.
- **Hoisin-sesame dip:** 3 tbsp hoisin sauce, 2 tbsp warm water, 1 tsp rice vinegar and a few drops of sesame oil. Stir until smooth and top with toasted sesame seeds and a little chili if you like. The classic partner for gỏi cuốn.
- **Thai sweet chili (nam chim kai):** a bottle is fine. To make it, blend 3 red chilies with 3 garlic cloves, then simmer with half a cup each of sugar, vinegar and water and 1 tsp salt for 5 minutes. Thicken with 1 tsp starch in a spoon of cold water. Keeps in the fridge for weeks *(estimate)*.
- **Soy-ginger sesame dip:** 2 tbsp soy sauce, 1 tbsp rice vinegar, 1 tsp finely grated ginger, 1 tsp honey and a few drops of sesame oil, with sliced scallion. Great with salmon rolls and dumplings too.

Pairing guide: fresh rolls with hoisin-sesame or nước chấm, chả giò with nước chấm, po pia tod and lumpia with sweet chili, salmon rolls with soy-ginger.



SECTION VIII · MAKE-AHEAD AND STORAGE

Rolling Ahead

- **Fresh rolls are best within 2–4 hours.** Keep them apart, under a damp paper towel or cloth, in a closed box.
- **To keep them overnight:** wrap each roll on its own in plastic wrap and refrigerate. They keep about **1 day** *(estimate)*. The rice paper firms up in the fridge, so let them sit at room temperature for 15–20 minutes before eating.
- **Don't freeze fresh rolls.** The rice paper and lettuce turn soggy and fall apart.
- **Prep the fillings ahead instead:** cooked shrimp, pork, noodles and cut vegetables keep 1–2 days in the fridge *(estimate)*. Roll when you're ready to eat.
- **Fried rolls, freeze before frying:** lay the uncooked rolls on a tray, not touching, freeze for about 2 hours until hard, then move them to a bag. They keep about **3 months** *(estimate)*. Cook them straight from frozen with no thawing: deep-fry at **160–170°C / 320–340°F** for 6–8 minutes, or air fry at **190°C / 375°F** for 16–20 minutes.
- **Or freeze after frying:** cool the fried rolls completely on a rack, then freeze. Reheat in the air fryer at **180°C / 350°F** for 8–10 minutes from frozen. Skip the microwave, which makes them soggy.
- Freezing before frying gives the crispest result. Freezing after frying is quickest on a busy night.



SECTION IX · HOW THEY SIT

A Digestion Note

On your digestion scale, **fresh rolls sit at tier 5–6**. That's because of the raw herbs, lettuce, cucumber and carrot inside. They're fresh and light on oil, but raw vegetables are more work for your stomach than cooked ones. **Fried rolls sit at tier 7**, because of the oil and the crisp, fried wrapper. On a day your stomach wants something gentler, have fewer rolls with a bowl of rice or soup, go easy on the chili in the dip, and choose the fresh rolls over the fried ones. On a good day, a few fried rolls next to a big fresh roll makes a happy plate.



SECTION X · THAI PRICES

What It Costs

These are your own purchases from Freshket and Paleo Robbie. No web prices were checked for this chapter, and prices change.

Item	Store	Pack	Paid	Date
Whole carrots	Freshket	1 kg	฿16	Sep 13, 2026
Thai mint	Paleo Robbie	50 g	฿59	Mar 19, 2026
Ripe Nam Dok Mai mango, size 1	Freshket	1 kg	฿180	Sep 13, 2026
Salmon belly, frozen	Freshket	1 kg	฿239	Nov 24, 2025
Sun Valley chicken tenderloin, frozen	Freshket	1 kg	฿110	Aug 12, 2026
Neville organic eggs	Freshket	30 eggs	฿189	Nov 18, 2025
Mature ginger	Freshket	250 g	฿25	Dec 26, 2025

Not priced yet: rice paper, wheat wrappers, shrimp, ground pork, rice vermicelli, lettuce, cucumber and the sauces aren't in your records yet. Send me the receipts after your next shop and I'll work out the cost of a batch.



Closing

Dip it quick, roll it tight, keep them apart, and never let the oil get lazy. One fold, a dozen kinds of roll. Go get rolling, baby.

Sources

- Safe internal temperatures: pork 71°C / 160°F for ground pork, poultry 74°C / 165°F, fish 63°C / 145°F, from the USDA FSIS safe minimum temperature chart.
- Wrapper types, soaking, rolling, frying and double-frying: common published Vietnamese, Thai, Chinese and Filipino home-cooking practice, summarized in plain words.
- Air fryer, freezing and storage times: common published practice, labeled as estimates.
- Prices: Julius's own price records (Freshket and Paleo Robbie purchases).